
ANI

but the party ultimately backed them, largely in the hope of reclaiming tribal support in the Kolhan region, where it failed to secure a single seat in 2019.

For Babulal Marandi—a former schoolteacher who became Jharkhand's first CM and now leads the BJP in the state—the stakes couldn't be higher. Having parted ways with the BJP in 2016, rejoined in 2020, and ascended to head the state unit in 2023, Marandi recognises this as his golden opportunity to return to the CM's chair he relinquished in 2003. The BJP brought Marandi back following a severe downturn in the 2019 assembly polls, where its Adivasi representation dropped from 11 to just two seats and the JMM-led combine triumphed in 25 of the 28 seats reserved for Scheduled Tribes. The BJP also lost all five ST-reserved Lok Sabha seats this year, underscoring how pivotal this election will be for Marandi's leadership and the party's future in Jharkhand.

As the two main coalitions—the JMM-led INDIA and the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA)—vie fiercely for control of the state, political heavyweights have shifted their campaign narratives away from policy, leaning instead on identity politics and emotionally charged appeals.

"UCC WILL BE INTRODUCED IN JHARKHAND. HOWEVER, IT WILL NOT BE ENFORCED ON THE TRIBAL COMMUNITIES"

AMIT SHAH, *Union Home Minister*

VS

"NEITHER UCC NOR NRC WILL BE ENFORCED. JHARKHAND WILL ONLY HAVE CNT AND SPT [TRIBAL LAND LAWS]"

HEMANT SOREN, *Chief Minister*

THE NDA ONSLAUGHT

On November 4, in Garhwa and Chaibasa, Prime Minister Narendra Modi advanced the BJP's new strategy of marrying Hindutva with Jharkhand's Adivasi nativism, alleging a conspiracy to alter the state's demography. He accused the JMM-Congress-RJD alliance of supporting *"ghuspaithiyas"* (shorthand for Bangladeshi infiltrators, often seen as a thinly veiled term for minorities) for electoral gains. Modi claimed these infiltrators target tribal girls, marrying them to seize their lands. From a prospective BJP regime, he promised strong measures to prevent infiltration and laws to return illegally seized land to tribal girls. The day before, in his first election meeting in Ghatshila, where Babulal Soren is contesting, Union home minister Amit Shah highlighted the declining tribal population in Jharkhand, attributing it to the influx of Bangladeshi infiltrators. He said, *"Aap kamal phool ki sarkar bana do, ek ek ghuspaithiye ko chun chun ke nikalne ka kaam BJP karegi. Adivasi ki beti, Adivasi ki roti aur Adivasi ki bhoomi, teenon ko bachaane ka kaam BJP karegi* (vote the BJP, and we will identify and remove each and every infiltrator. We will also work towards saving the daughters, livelihoods and the lands of the tribal communities)." BJP leaders, including Marandi, have repeatedly accused the JMM of engaging in vote bank politics that, they claim, could alter Jharkhand's cultural identity. They promise the introduction of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) as a "safeguard" for the state's interests. Shah also promised the implementation of a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Jharkhand, but excluding the tribal population from its ambit.

I.N.D.I.A.'S PUSHBACK

Whether Soren's appeal to voters to reject 'divisive' narratives holds will hinge on more than mere words. The INDIA bloc needs to harness its organisational muscle to counter the BJP-led coalition's cohesive mobilisation of resources. The ruling coalition has so far relied on its strong base among tribals, who comprise 26 per cent of the state's population, along with significant sup-